



and Kohli open up numerous possibilities for the side. The team now has the chance to establish a new T20I opening combination, with Jaiswal seemingly having secured one spot. Suryakumar Yadav can move to No. 3, while Rinku Singh can be slotted in as a death-overs power-hitter. His ability to take down pace bowlers from overs 17-20 will make his inclusion even more enticing.

The performance of spin-bowling all-rounder Axar Patel, both with the ball and the bat, has been outstanding, highlighted by his crucial 47 in the final. He will be the perfect replacement for Ravindra Jadeja, who also retired from T20 internationals a day after India's World Cup triumph. Axar's electrifying fielding is an added

bonus, further enhancing his value. It was a moment of redemption for all-rounder Hardik Pandya. After a challenging IPL 2024 campaign, both as captain and player, he redeemed himself spectacularly in this competition. He capped it off by successfully defending 15 runs in the last over. Hardik finished the tournament with 144 runs and 11 wickets in eight matches.

Meanwhile, it was heartbreak once again for South Africa at the final hurdle. The Proteas needed 26 runs from 24 balls to chase down a target of 177, but the wicket of Heinrich Klaasen, who scored 52 from 27 balls, shifted the momentum dramatically in India's favour. This match could well have been Quinton de Kock's final international appearance for his

Roaring success: Mercilessly booed by IPL crowds, Hardik Pandya bounced back to play a crucial role in India's T20 World Cup triumph, while Virat Kohli, who hadn't performed in eight games prior to the final, came good when it mattered. K. R. DEEPAK

country, leaving his successor some big shoes to fill. Despite the loss, there were many positives for the team, including Klaasen's excellent form, Aiden Markram's captaincy skills, and Ottniel Baartman's impressive bowling.

There was more anguish in store, this time for the 2022 world champion, England, which made it to the semifinals riding on a mix of some good cricket and dollops of luck. But in a bit of symmetry, after the events of Adelaide 2022, their run was snapped by rampant India spinners, who sent Jos Buttler's side tumbling to a 68-run defeat in Georgetown, Guyana. The low, slow surface there proved much too much for the Three Lions, whose power-hitters clearly like pace on.

Under the leadership of Jos Buttler and head coach Matthew Mott, England has lost both its white-ball world titles in the past seven months. Mott, who was appointed as the white-ball coach in 2022, quickly led the team to victory in the T20 World Cup in Australia. However, since then, the results have been mixed, raising questions about whether Mott will remain in charge for the upcoming series against Australia in September.

With no T20 World Cup for the next two years, England has time to reassess. The next edition will be held in India and Sri Lanka, where England is familiar with the conditions and will know how to improve. Additionally, the Champions Trophy in Pakistan next year will also feature slow, low pitches, similar to those that have recently exposed England's inability to perform on such surfaces. Rob Key, the managing director of England men's cricket, faces a considerable challenge ahead. A complete reboot could be on the cards, including debates over